Red Flags

by Jura Fearnley

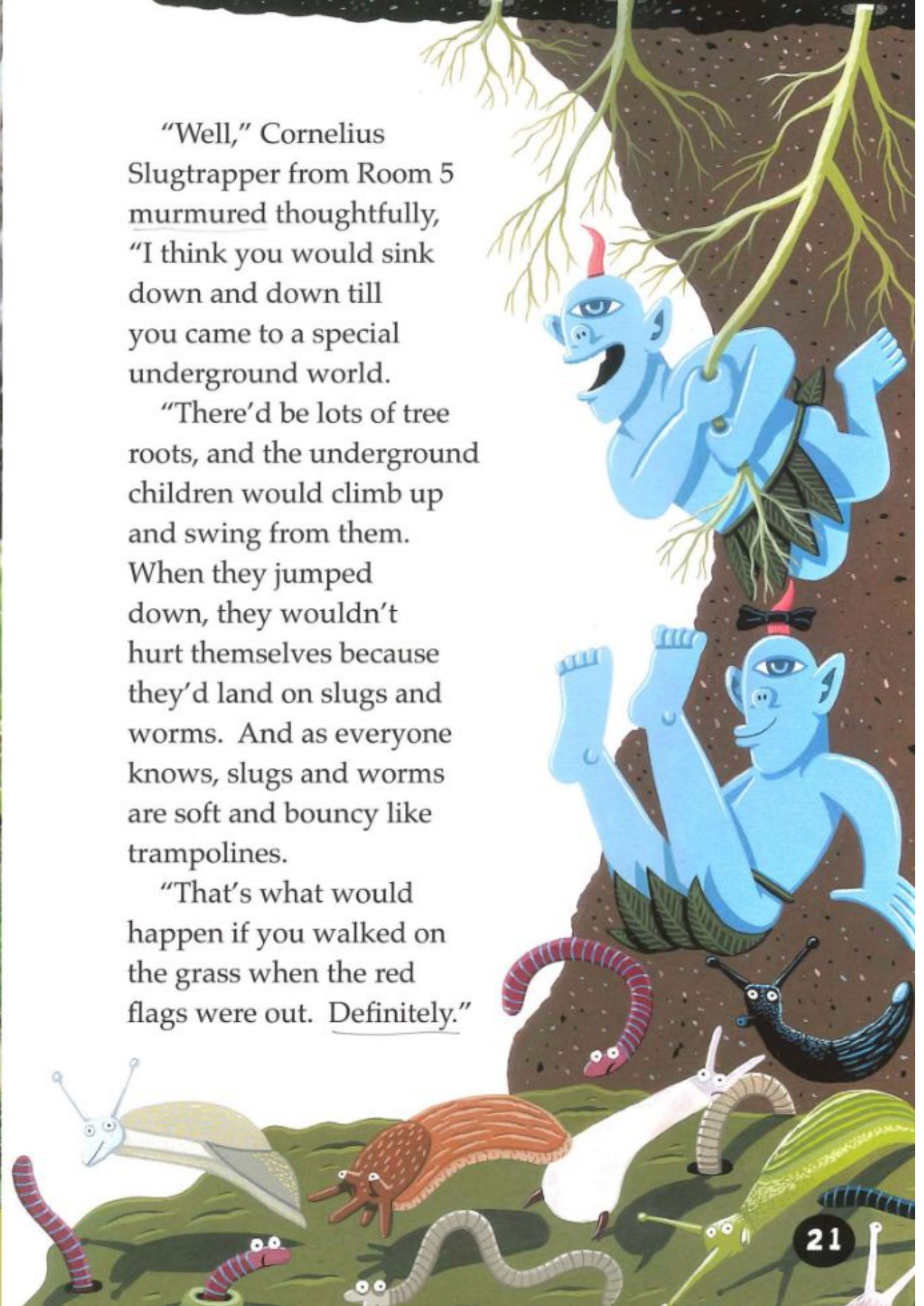
At assembly, the teacher said, "It's raining today, and the red flags are out. So remember – please do not walk on the grass."

"What would happen if we did?" asked Molly McMerry from Room 2.

"Well," Cornelius Slugtrapper from Room 5 murmured thoughtfully, "I think you would sink down and down till you came to a special underground world.

"There'd be lots of tree roots, and the underground children would climb up and swing from them. When they jumped down, they wouldn't hurt themselves because they'd land on slugs and worms. And as everyone knows, slugs and worms are soft and bouncy like trampolines.

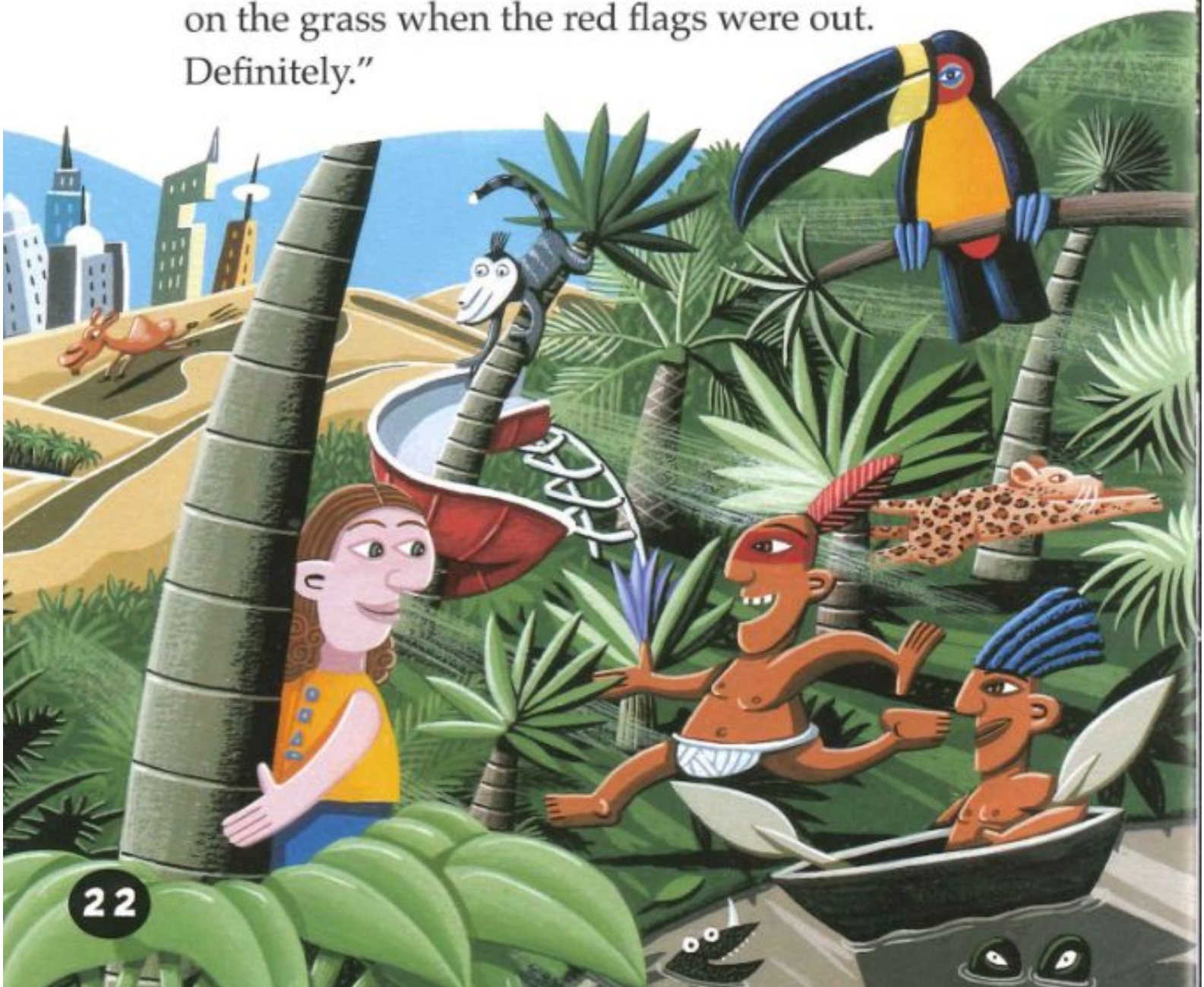
"That's what would happen if you walked on the grass when the red flags were out. Definitely."



"I disagree," said Agnes Argumenta from Room 6. "*I* think you would sink and sink and sink – and then pop out on the other side of the world. You'd arrive in a playground just like ours, but it would be surrounded by jungles and deserts, toucans and camels – and skyscrapers.

"All the children would run up to welcome you saying, 'Bonjour!', 'Guten Tag!', 'Bore da!', and 'Hola!'

"That's what would happen if you walked on the grass when the red flags were out. Definitely."

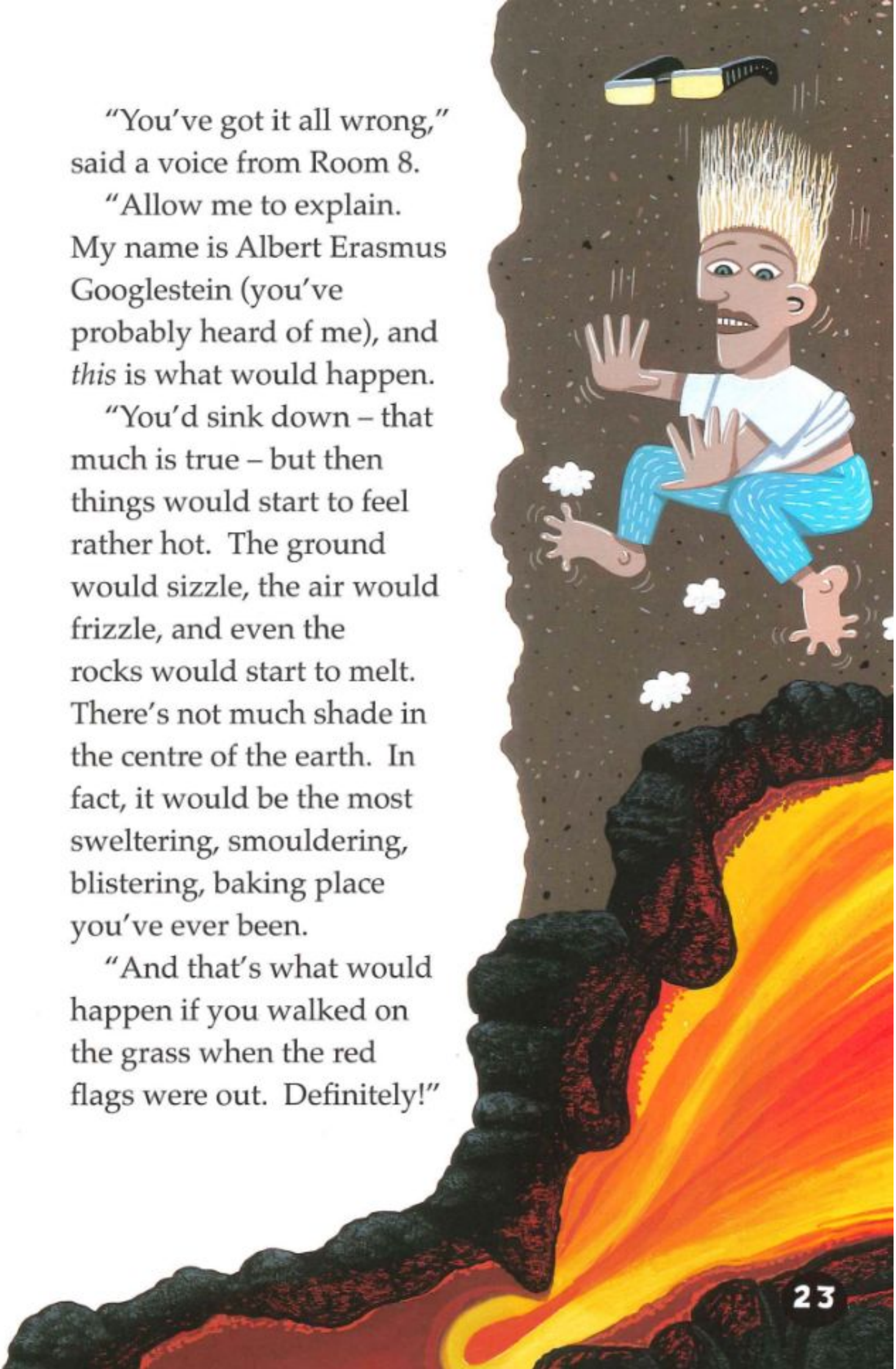


"You've got it all wrong," said a voice from Room 8.

"Allow me to explain. My name is Albert Erasmus Googlestein (you've probably heard of me), and *this* is what would happen.

"You'd sink down – that much is true – but then things would start to feel rather hot. The ground would sizzle, the air would frizzle, and even the rocks would start to melt. There's not much shade in the centre of the earth. In fact, it would be the most sweltering, smouldering, blistering, baking place you've ever been.

"And that's what would happen if you walked on the grass when the red flags were out. Definitely!"



"Wrong!" yelled the Twiggy twins from Room 1.

"You're so wrong it's not funny," said Twiggy 1.

"I'm not even smiling a little bit," said Twiggy 2.

"If you walked on the grass, a great, big, slimy, sticky monster with four brains ..." began Twiggy 1.

"... and sixteen eyes," chimed in Twiggy 2.

"... would slither up to you and wrap its tentacles around your throat and squeeze ..."

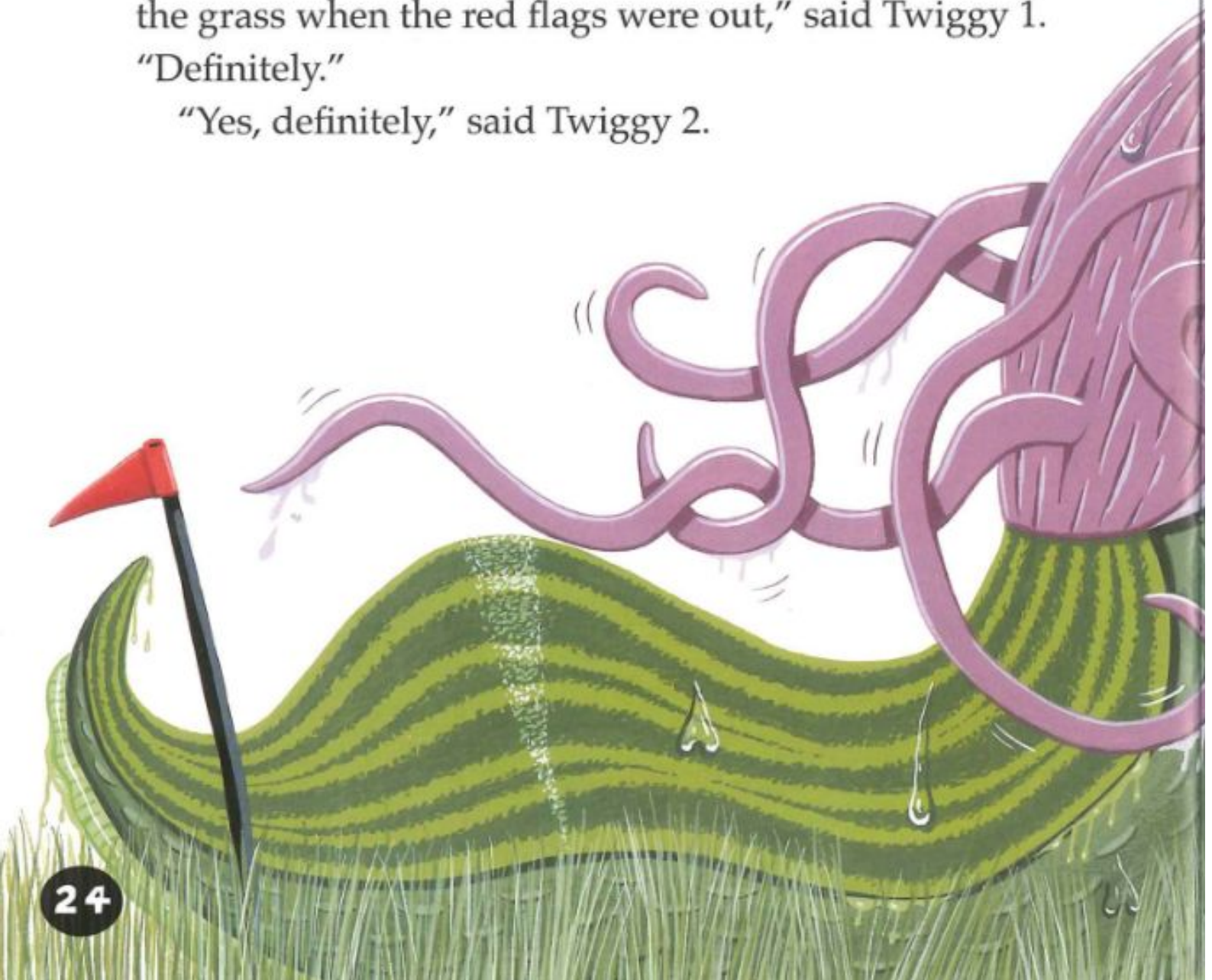
"... and squeeze ..."

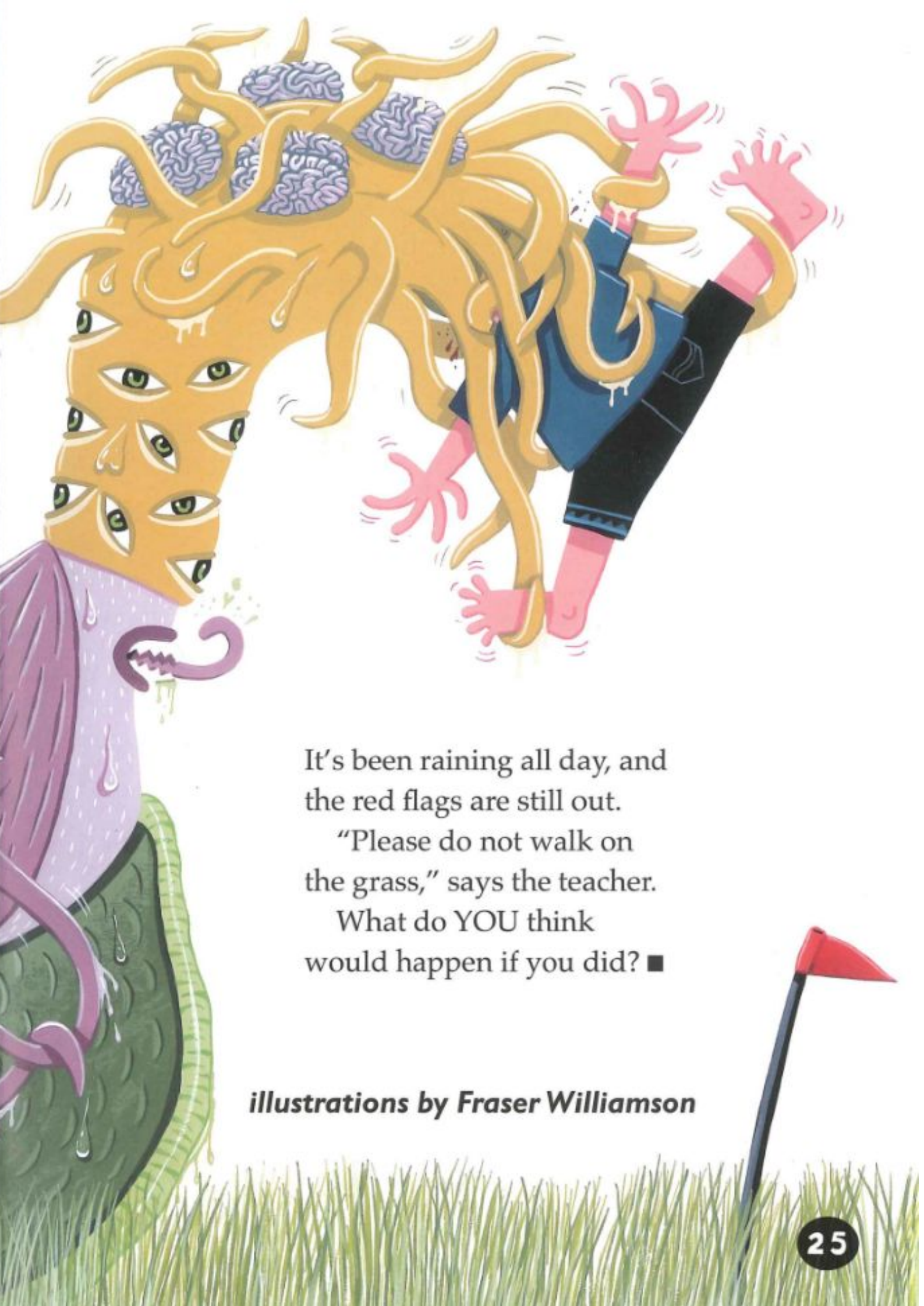
"... and squeeze you like a pimple until ..."

"... SPLAT!"

"And that's what would happen if you walked on the grass when the red flags were out," said Twiggy 1. "Definitely."

"Yes, definitely," said Twiggy 2.





It's been raining all day, and the red flags are still out.

"Please do not walk on the grass," says the teacher.

What do YOU think would happen if you did? ■

illustrations by Fraser Williamson